

THE SHORT VERSION · COSTA RICA · SINCE 1991

Costa Rica, *in four pages*

The fast facts: when to go, where to go for your kind of trip, ten places not to miss and the animals to look for. Read it over one coffee.

IF YOU ONLY REMEMBER THREE THINGS

1

Pick your season. December to April for sunshine; July to October for turtles, whales and fewer people.

2

Two bases, not five. Fly between far regions. The map says two hours; the road says four.

3

Dawn is the good part. Wildlife, light and the trails are all at their best before breakfast.

JAMES WILD & CO. · LEDGERED & VETTED · JOURNEY DESIGN SINCE 1982

WHEN TO GO

Where to be, month by month

December to April is dry and sunny on the Pacific side. May to November is the green season: afternoon rain, roaring waterfalls, turtles, whales and fewer people.

January · MONTEVERDE · CLOUD FOREST
Quetzal season begins. The bird is real; your guide knows which tree.

February · CARIBBEAN COAST
The Caribbean side dries out. Reef, reggae and nobody on the beach.

March · GUANACASTE
The sunniest month in the northwest. Pack sunscreen like you mean it.

April · ARENAL
Last of the dry season. Easter week is busy: book early or go late.

May · PACUARE · TURRIALBA
First rains, first green. The forest exhales.

June · PACUARE RIVER
The rivers rise and the rafting gets lively. Hold on.

July · PACIFIC COAST · TORTUGUERO
The "little summer" on the Pacific, and green turtles begin nesting.

August · UVITA · OSA
Humpbacks offshore in the morning, waterfalls in the afternoon.

September · CARIBBEAN COAST
The Pacific gets soaked; the Caribbean smiles. Go east.

October · TORTUGUERO
Turtle hatchlings sprint for the sea. The quietest month, and the best-kept secret.

November · OSA PENINSULA
Shoulder season: fewer people, fair weather, good rates.

December · EVERYWHERE
Dry season returns, and so does everyone. We booked your room in June.

WHO IT'S FOR

Your kind of trip, at a glance

IF YOU'RE…	GO	WHERE	OUR PICK
First-timers	Dec–Apr	Arenal · Monteverde · Guanacaste	Two Oceans, One Volcano
Families, young kids	Dec–Apr · July	Arenal · Papagayo	Four Seasons Papagayo
Teens & three generations	Jun–Aug · Dec	Pacuare · Arenal · the Osa	Pacuare Lodge
Honeymooners	Dec–Apr	Rincón de la Vieja · the Osa	Origins Lodge
Wildlife lovers & birders	Dec–Apr birds · Jul–Oct turtles & whales	The Osa · Tortuguero · Monteverde	Lapa Rios
Wellness seekers	May–Nov	Nosara · Arenal	Nayara Springs · Harmony

JAMES SAYS: DON'T MISS THIS ONE

Ten places, one map



1 Tortuguero canals · CARIBBEAN COAST
No roads, all canals. Turtles nest July to October; caimans work the day shift.

2 Arenal's hot river · LA FORTUNA
A volcano-warmed river where the locals soak for free. Nature's jacuzzi, no booking required.

3 Río Celeste · TENORIO VOLCANO NATIONAL PARK
Where two rivers meet and turn sky-blue. It looks retouched. It isn't.

4 Monteverde hanging bridges · CLOUD FOREST
Walk the canopy at cloud level. Go early; the quetzals don't do crowds.

5 Tárcoles River bridge · CENTRAL PACIFIC
Dozens of crocodiles posing below. The best free photo op that can also eat you.

6 Corcovado, Sirena station · THE OSA PENINSULA
The wildest walk in Central America. Tapirs, macaws and mud to the knee.

7 The whale's tail · MARINO BALLENA, UVITA
At low tide the sandbar draws a whale's tail. The real ones swim past in season.

8 Ostional arribadas · NICOYA PENINSULA
On arribada nights, thousands of olive ridley turtles come ashore together. Nature's flash mob.

9 Tarrazú coffee farms · LOS SANTOS HIGHLANDS
The best cup of your life, poured by the person who picked it.

10 Rincón de la Vieja · GUANACASTE
Bubbling mud pots and steaming vents. The volcano smells faintly of breakfast eggs.

The rest, in short

LOOK FOR	WHERE	BEST
Sloths, two- and three-toed	everywhere with trees	all year
Scarlet macaws	the Osa · Carara	all year
Resplendent quetzal	Monteverde · San Gerardo de Dota	Dec–Apr [confirm]
Red-eyed tree frog	lowland rainforest, at night	all year
Humpback whales	Marino Ballena · Uvita · the Osa	Jul–Oct · Dec–Mar
Sea turtles	Tortuguero · Ostional	Jul–Oct

GIVE SPACE TO

- **Fer-de-lance:** stay on the trail, closed shoes, a guide after dark.
- **Capuchins:** they steal lunches. Zip everything.
- **Crocodiles and rip currents:** no swimming in river mouths; lifeguarded beaches only.

SEVEN STAYS WE'D BOOK

1. Nayara Springs · ARENAL
2. Lapa Rios Lodge · OSA PENINSULA
3. Pacuare Lodge · PACUARE RIVER
4. Origins Lodge · RINCÓN DE LA VIEJA
5. Four Seasons Peninsula Papagayo · GUANACASTE
6. Hacienda AltaGracia · PÉREZ ZELEDÓN
7. Harmony Hotel Nosara · NOSARA



Humpbacks, twice a year

FIVE RULES OF THE ROAD

Fly the far ones · Never drive after dark · Two nights minimum anywhere you fly to · The side with the "Ceda el paso" sign waits · Book December to April early

QR

WANT THE WHOLE STORY?

This is the short version. The 24-page field guide has the journeys, the lodges, the wildlife spread and every wrong turn I've taken since 1991. Or skip the reading and text me.

James

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